

# Jack IWA Peer Reviewed

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## reviewing notes:

advices/notes — in the footnote in the bottom of each page.

orange boxes containing text — possible changes recommended.

other marginpars: reading notes.

this file was constructed through LaTeX.

**Research Question:** How can social interventions be optimized to overcome social isolation and loneliness within the East Asian nursing homes?

After people get older, they need other people to take care of them as their capability of self-management decreases. Under many situations, their family members, especially sons and daughters, will take responsibility for taking care of elders in families. However, their children have to take working as their priority so that there is little time to distribute their energies on taking care of elders. In order to cope with this problem, children send their elderly parents to nursing homes, and the pressure against their families is decreased (Jung, 2018). Meanwhile, going to nursing homes leads to another new problem. Murakami (2013) proposes that “the older a person gets, the lonelier he becomes”(Section 3, para. 10). With the aging procedure, the sense of loneliness and social isolation becomes more significant. Moreover, with the development of the society, the living environment and location change again and again (2013), which indicates that the changes of living locations and environments<sup>1</sup> resulting in the (a) sense of loneliness. Moving from home to various nursing homes is a change of living locations, which causes loneliness according to Murakami. For elders, the effect of moving into nursing homes would be more significant than that for normal populations.<sup>2</sup>

Jackie’s Kerbar, i am (already) looking forward to review your wonderful article with you a 5 in seminar external exam.

conflict setting

proving that existing solutions cannot truly solve the conflict

adding “increase of the” after “resulting in a”

<sup>1</sup>not really natural, a bit redundant, recommend to delete highlighted part

<sup>2</sup>why? is this personal speculation or evidence-based claim, or is this also from Murakami’s research? I think you may either provide valid reasoning or citation from research.

According to U.S. Department of Health and Human Services (2023), a department led by United States government that protects the health of all Americans and provides essential human services, “social connection is a significant predictor of longevity and better physical, cognitive, and mental health, while social isolation and loneliness are significant predictors of premature death and poor health” (p. 23). The extent of social connection for elders decides whether their health conditions go well. If elders are under a situation that provides opportunities to develop social networks, their health conditions are extraordinarily excellent in every perspective<sup>3</sup>. They can even possess better longevity in this way, and vice versa. Therefore, the importance of finding an appropriate strategy that resolves the problem of social isolation and loneliness within nursing homes is significant and urgent.<sup>4</sup>

## 0.1 Causes of Social Isolation and Loneliness in Nursing Homes

For those old people who initially live alone home, nursing homes might be a good choice to stay at. Elders in the “living alone” community with poor social support or low psychological health score are associated with long-time living alone, no children, involuntarily living alone, and no jobs (Huang & Lin, 2002)<sup>5</sup>. This indicates that factors of long-time living alone, no children, involuntarily living alone, and no jobs result in few social connections or even no social connections. To resolve this problem of elders, the point is creating opportunities to develop social connections and networks. In this way, nursing homes are better than their current environment as the environment of nursing homes at least provides peers and staffs who they can communicate with. From U.S. Department of Health and Human Services (2023), “Wider social networks and more frequent social engagements with friends and family are associated with better cognitive function and may protect against the risk of dementia.” (p. 29) Once they build up some social contacts among individuals, their health conditions will (may) get improved, and the predicted longevity will be more opti-

adding a significance for this issue by citing a federal authority’s sentence. but would it be better adding a more specific ‘name of document’ when citing? since only the institution is mentioned (add something like ‘According to a xxx report by U.S. Department of Health and Human Services (2023)’ may be better, i think.)

this part is attempting to prove the benefits that nursing homes could bring to elderlys, especially for those living alone without necessary social connections.

\*live alone at home

wording: ‘could be better’ may be better

could result in

<sup>3</sup>maybe the wording is a bit too absolute

<sup>4</sup>highlighted part redundant? try phrases like ”of great significance to...”

<sup>5</sup>this sentence is hard to follow, you repetatively described ‘living alone’ twice

mistic as well. Although elders who only build social interactions in nursing homes might not possess as many social connections as normal people, the change of “wider social networks” is adequate to make a significant difference for them. Consequently, those elders who initially live alone home can be directly benefited from nursing homes.

On the other hand, for the oldest elders, their core reliance is economic support and daily care from their sons and daughters (Zhong et al., 2024). This indicates that moving into nursing homes might be equal to forcing them to be isolated from initial reliance, which probably leads to more serious barriers in their life—they lose the mere pathway to the society when they stay in nursing homes. Older adults who are not able to have family visitors are more likely to suffer more significant social isolation (Chaudhury&Xu, 2022). This implies that hospitalization of nursing homes, which are specialized to provide service for older adults, can result in more serious subsequent outcomes. In addition, many Chinese women treat families more seriously under the background of Chinese traditional culture (Zhong et al., 2024). They take families as crucial positions in their mind, and female adults who have carried heavy burdens are important characters in families. As a result, they expected to choose nursing homes closer to their own home, which means physical distance between actual homes and nursing homes becomes a vital factor during the process of choosing nursing homes. If those elders are forced to be separated from families due to nursing homes, they might think their own functions as a family member are declined in the families, so they subjectively demonstrate meaningless life. Then they feel more isolated and lonely in nursing homes.

Another cause is that nursing homes are hospitalized nowadays. According to a study from Chaudhury (2022), a professor in Simon Fraser University who has a great interest in physical environment in long-term care settings, and the colleague, in general, nursing homes in Asia are likely to be smaller in size, and there are greater amount of elders sharing the same room, more institutional infrastructures, and fewer social spaces provided. The changes suggest that the style of nursing homes becomes hospitalized, and the renewed environments are not appropriate to conduct social activities and interactions. Based on this, it is inferred that the behaviors of nursing home administrators

discourage elders to establish social connections, which leads to the sense of loneliness and social isolation.

## **0.2 Necessity of Interventions**

Currently, there's a risk that threatens elders to become more socially isolated and lonely in nursing homes. Welch(2023), a researcher in University of Ottawa who gains great interest in health equity assessment in guidelines, trials and systematic reviews, and her colleagues propose, "Interventions may target all older adults regardless of their risk (universal) or a subpopulation of older adults who are at risk, for example, those living in nursing homes (selective) or may target those who are socially isolated or lonely (indicated)"(p. 7). It is necessary to establish proper interventions to resolve problems of loneliness and social isolation in nursing homes. Gardiner (2018), a professor in University of Sheffield who covers majors of Allied Health, Pharmacy, Nursing and Midwifery, and colleagues suggest that an effective intervention is identified with three characteristics: adaptability, community development and productive engagement. Under conditions of the problem, the solution with these three characteristics can successfully support the lonely individual as a form of social facilitation.

## **0.3 Available Existing Solutions**

The first current solution that has been conducted is about befriending program. Brand (2024), who is in the research department of clinical, educational and health psychology in University College London, gives the definition of befriending program. "Befriending, a voluntary, purposeful relationship which is initiated, supported and monitored by an agency (Dean & Goodlad, 1998) is one intervention that aims to increase social inclusion, develop relationships and enhance community participation" (p. 1) Befriending program carries out some measures that are against the changes of current nursing homes mentioned above. It aims to heal adults with mental health problems especially for those elders who feel socially isolated and lonely.

Befriending program promotes social connections through four themes: “something fun for me”, “a good connection”, “increasing independence”, “a life less quiet” (Brand et al., 2024). First, something fun for me indicates the significance of common decision making in the befriending relationship (2024). Elders who feel lonely in nursing homes will make decisions with befriending partner together, and the formation of common ideas underlines the existence of elders, which helps elders understand that their decisions are not meaningless. Thus, the sense of social isolation declines for elders in nursing homes. Second, “a good connection” highlights the positive influences of befriending extend further than one-to-one relationship (2024). Befriending program offers more opportunities to mainstream activities. The staffs in befriending program also provide psychological support, which creates safety and cultivates the competence of being independent. It aligns with the third theme “increasing independence” as well. Last but not the least, “a less quiet life” refers to a life that more people engage in. Elders in the nursing homes find their own groups, so they get less isolated and even create own communities. Meanwhile, the life quality gets promoted due to befriending program. (Mchugh et al., 2025). The life is less quiet, yet its quality is improved. Here’s an example about befriending volunteers of college students in China. “University students regularly visit residents voluntarily, talk with them, and perform group activities, providing emotional support and companionship.” (Sun et al., 2020, p. 7) Demonstrating filial piety, they play a role of connecting external world and internal psychological world for elders. Nevertheless, there are a few limitations while befriending is being conducted. Since the befriending relationship is excludable for those who decide not to continuously pay for it, the endings of befriending underline the tensions and difference between actual friendship and befriending partnership, which is a type of formal intervention used for curing (Brand et al., 2024). Elders who accept befriending usually experience multiple separations from their partners, and they are really emotionally affected by these endings. Thus, the endings and uncertain variations of befriending program are seen as a vital source of anxiety for participants in nursing homes. Participants are difficult to adapt to different relationship in short-run. Overall, befriending program aligns with two of the three characteristics: community development and productive engagement.

The next solution is called “smaller-scale nursing homes” that can arrange many benefits as well. In the past, a crucial aspect that contributes to the loneliness in nursing homes was the lack of self-worth and regular daily schedule, yet a small-scale nursing home offers opportunities to create own companions for specific social benefits and exercise every day (Jung, 2018). This can effectively resolve the problem of self awareness and routine life and indirectly improve life quality in nursing homes. However, it possesses weaker community development because its physical scale limits the development. Consequently, it reaches two of the three characteristics of successful interventions—adaptability and productive engagement.

The third available solution is about smart nursing homes. Mokhtar (2022), who is from Singapore Institute of Technology, proposes a suggestion about online interaction. The administrators of nursing homes can introduce online video phone call facilities for elders so that they can connect to families without the barriers of physical distance. Especially for the oldest adults who rely on children, the mean probably becomes the only way that provides emotional support and external connection. There is a practical example in China, which is not limited within online phone calls. Zhao (2023), a researcher from The School of Smart Health and Wellness (Health Medical College), Zhejiang Dongfang Polytechnic, and colleagues discovers that a smart nursing home integrates nursing care and medical treatment to control chronic disease and provide quality services. In contrast, it is sometimes challenging as the Internet connection cannot be guaranteed in every region(2022). It possesses two of the three characteristics of effective strategies: adaptability and productive engagement. The community development isn’t reached cause the intermediate that allows elders to contact external world is still simple and not improved.

Last but not the least, the collaboration between governments and companies is proposed. Different types of firms can communicate and interact for their common social objectives. Then they will collude and send a final application to the government to seek for financial aid (Wang et al., 2022). Based on this procedure, the nursing program would be more specialized and more straightforward to reach the goal and efficiency. The sense of loneliness of elders is more likely to decline through professional agencies. On the other hand, this solution merely

focuses on outside methods instead of elders themselves, so productive engagement is not reached due to the lack of subjective willingness of engagement for elder populations. Therefore, the strategy aligns with two of the three characteristics of effective solutions: adaptability and community development.

## 0.4 Conclusion and Limitation

Nursing homes cause loneliness and social isolation through physical distance from home and hospitalization. The existing solutions mentioned above, including befriending program, small-scale nursing home, smart nursing home and collaboration between companies and governments, are successful to overcome the problem in various extents. However, none of them attain all three characteristics of effective interventions. Befriending program doesn't attain adaptability. Small-scale nursing home doesn't attain community development. Smart nursing home doesn't reach community development as well. Collaborations between companies and governments don't achieve productive engagement. This indicates that the solutions aren't completely effective. Additionally, Ma (2019), a researcher from Zhejiang University, and colleagues suggest that sending older adults to nursing homes is considered as a means that children abandon their parents. It is misunderstood under the cultural conflict of East Asia (Jung, 2018). Since culture is difficult to be modified in short-run, and it is accumulated for many years, current interventions in nursing homes cannot be fully optimized to overcome social isolation and loneliness.

### Reviewer's Opinion

— try to clarify conceptual differences between *loneliness* and *social isolation*, because loneliness is more like 'subjective feeling', while isolation is typically describing an 'subjective condition/status'.